...there can be no question but that the withdrawal of this force from North Persia at the present juncture would exercise a deplorable effect on the political situation generally. It would leave Teheran [sic] a prey to the Bolshevik sources should the Soviet Government decide actually to invade Persia, and in any case it would shake the stability of the Persian Government and expose them to all the anti-British propaganda that would most certainly be instituted...[29]

Even the Indian government agreed that there was no simple answer, noting that withdrawal of its troops from Persia could affect Britain's reputation both in that country and in other southern Asian states, such as Afghanistan. (Although, it also pointed out that since India was little affected by events in Persia, it really raised no objection to such withdrawal.)[30] Ultimately, at a meeting of the Eastern Committee on 12 January 1920, it was decided that no reinforcements were to be sent to Persia and that none of the troops there were to be withdrawn either.[31]

Churchill took exception, protesting to the Cabinet at the apparent absurdity of retaining within Persia a force that, while being an enormous drain on the military's finances, was insufficient to prevent any serious attack on that country anyway.[32] Despite Churchill's complaints, however, it was agreed in Cabinet on 18 February that the general officer commander in Mesopotamia would be directed to hold his forces at Enzeli and attempt to bluff the Bolsheviks out of making an incursion there. Should this fail, however, and an attack took place, there was no intention of holding on to Enzeli and the troops should retreat.[33] For, as Curzon pointed out to Cox, it was not really 'understood by us why a country with a population of 10 millions, even if it be Persia, should allow itself to be conquered by a few thousand armed robbers from without'. In any event, 'it is most improbable that [the] Bolsheviks will make any attack in force against Persia, and [the] possibility may practically be discounted'.[34]

I Told You So